

By
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THE FIGHT FOR HINDU VALUES

HINDUISM'S GRAND, COMPLEX AND CEREBRAL LEGACY HAS BEEN REDUCED TO ITS LOWEST COMMON DENOMINATOR BY HINDUTVA FANATICS. REAL HINDUS MUST STAND UP, FIGHT THIS DIVIDE

Perhaps nothing better sums up the conquering eclecticism of Hinduism than these lines from the 'Nasadiya Sukta' in the Rig Veda, the first recorded rumination in Hindu philosophy on the origins of the universe: 'Who really knows? Who will here proclaim it? Whence was it produced? Whence this creation? The gods came afterwards with the creation of this universe? Who then knows whence it has risen?'

This hymn is remarkable for its absence of dogma; there are no certitudes; no injunction for obeisance; no religious commands or call to ritual. There is awe, there is wonderment, but, above all, there is inquiry, an emphasis on the need to ask, to probe, to go beyond conventional categories of thought to the realm of speculation, an invitation to ideation.

This self-assured non-prescriptive nature of Hinduism was proclaimed by our founding seers. *Ekam sat bipraha bahudha vadhanti (*The truth is one, wise people, call it by different names) has been the key to Hinduism's tensile strength. *Anno bhadraha kritvo yantu vishvataha* (Let good thoughts flow to me from all directions) was its clarion call for openness to thought. *Udar charitanam vasudhaiva kutumbukam* (For the big hearted the entire world is a family) was its motto for an inclusiveness of spirit. That is why Hindu philosophy had not one but six systems of thought, each focused less on conventional divinity and more on what the ultimate truth could be behind the bewildering plurality of the cosmos. Not surprisingly, even the Charvakas, whose materialism compelled them to call the Vedas a lie, were a part of Hinduism. As Mahatma Gandhi wrote: 'If I know Hinduism at all, it is essentially inclusive and ever growing, ever responsive. It gives the freest scope to imagination, speculation and reason.'

Hindutva seeks to convert such a *sanatana dharma* to a Wahhabi style faith, thereby posing a threat to the very essence of Hinduism. Hindutva fanatics have reduced Hinduism's grand, nuanced and complex cerebral legacy to its lowest common denominator. Masquerading as the self-anointed protectors of Hinduism, they are the stormtroopers of the BJP-RSS. What are their distinguishing